

## Episode 21: Once Upon a Time... (16) *Saint Seiya* Part 3 – Steel Saints

**Last weekend, my beloved laptop PowerBook G4 wouldn't start up.** The cause was hard disc failure. A year and a half after purchase. Considering usage frequency, ah, from experience it's about time for problems to occur (cries).

**Now I'm in trouble.**

**I have several computers at home and work, but the centre of it all is that broken PowerBook.** I manage various things on that PowerBook. Actually, I write this manuscript on the PowerBook too.

**Well, I couldn't use that as an excuse to say "Sorry, I'll skip this week's series..." (bitter laugh), so I hurriedly replaced the hard disc myself and got it temporarily revived.** What a relief. I'm writing this properly now (laughs).

**The problem is the dead hard disc.** Actually, it contained very important photo data. I usually back up regularly every 3 months, and I was planning to do it this weekend after June ended. Ah, regret doesn't help (wails). I'll do it more frequently from now on.

**So everyone, please back up important data frequently (cries).**

Well then.

**"*Saint Seiya*" that somehow got started.**

**I don't remember watching Episode 1 during the original broadcast.** Like Morishita-san's comment after that Episode 1 first screening, I honestly didn't think it would become such a hit either. Also, actually, due to staff error, my name wasn't included in Episode 1's end credits.

**Toei Doga work credits back then didn't have "colour direction" or "inspection."** They'd list about 4 names under "finishing," and colour direction would be mixed in there (usually at the top). But somehow they forgot to include my name.

**This was depressing.** Disappointed watching the first screening (bitter laugh). This kind of thing is actually very important. Being credited proves you were involved in the work, and with TV, parents, siblings, friends, and acquaintances can see and properly recognise it, plus it raises your own motivation.

**So back then when I was still young, not having my name there probably dropped my "motivation" somewhat, and maybe that's why I didn't watch the original broadcast? (laughs)**

**Moreover, from Episode 2 onward, it basically left my hands.** Unlike the current system where "colour design" oversees the entire series, per-episode colour direction and inspection were all left to the finishing production company handling that episode.

**As I wrote last time, guest character colour direction was all handled directly from art designers and the art department to each finishing production company, and colour continuity between episodes was mainly managed by assistant directors and production progress.** The finishing department managed cut flow but we had no involvement in colour matters. Something like that.

**Also, every few episodes, production company Lifework entered the production rotation.** Lifework's episodes for *Saint Seiya* were handled consistently by Lifework from direction through animation and finishing. **Ishizaki Susumu's** directed episodes were like this.

**Lifework used Taiyo Shikisai cel paints for colouring.** As I wrote before, Toei Doga used STAC cel paints, but back then most other companies used Taiyo Shikisai cel

paints. So Lifework's colour director converted STAC→Taiyo Shikisai based on *Saint Seiya* colour direction created at Toei Doga.

**With today's digital colouring, such problems don't exist at all, but back then such effort was required.** STAC paints with good colour development clarity versus Taiyo Shikisai with many subdued colours. You couldn't make them exactly the same. So in Lifework production episodes, **Seiya** and other characters' colours were somewhat different. But thanks to the colour director's good sense in organising them, you can't tell the difference unless you look very carefully.

**So *Saint Seiya* TV series production proceeded without me (laughs).** The initially hectic production situation settled down, popularity gradually increased, and about half a year passed.

**Whenever there were problems, they'd come to me.** And such a problem arose.

**A new main-treatment character was to appear.** While I had no involvement with per-episode guest characters, for main-treatment characters appearing throughout the series, I was to create colour direction sheets - that was the arrangement.

**The new character.** Moreover, they wanted to create and feature new Saints not in the original work. Three Saints wearing **Saint Cloths** designed and created with the pinnacle of scientific technology. Their name: "**Steel Saints**."

**As usual, designs came from the sponsor toy manufacturer.** Frankly speaking, very "toy-like" design, colours, and gimmicks. Hmm, this is...

**I think I received specifications for character skin colour and hair from** Kubota-san. Combining those to make colour samples. Then checking.

**The basic principle for this kind of thing is "the same shape and colour as what appears on TV is lined up in toy store displays."** So since product (toy) colours and colour divisions were already decided, the version appearing in the main story had to match the toys.

**"Well, this is how it'll be," so colour checking was also OK like that.** Thus "Steel Saints" appeared on TV, but...

**They only appeared in a few episodes, then were somehow buried in darkness, with no one mentioning their existence anymore.**

(07.07.03)